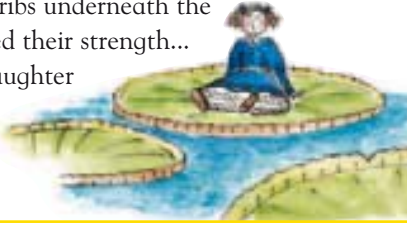


DON'T TRY THIS AT HOME

The leaves of the Amazon water lily can grow to 1.8 m (6 ft) across. As well as being large, they are surprisingly strong. This was discovered by Joseph Paxton, an English gardener, about 150 years ago. He noticed the ribs underneath the leaves and tested their strength... by asking his daughter to sit on a leaf in the middle of a pond!



Float on by

Floaters such as water hyacinths have roots that are the opposite of holdfasts. They are not anchored to the ground, but trail behind the plant as it swims along, picking up nutrients.



Through the surface

Emergent plants, such as lilies, are rooted in a pond or river bed, but grow tall to poke through the surface of the water. This enables them to reach the light.

